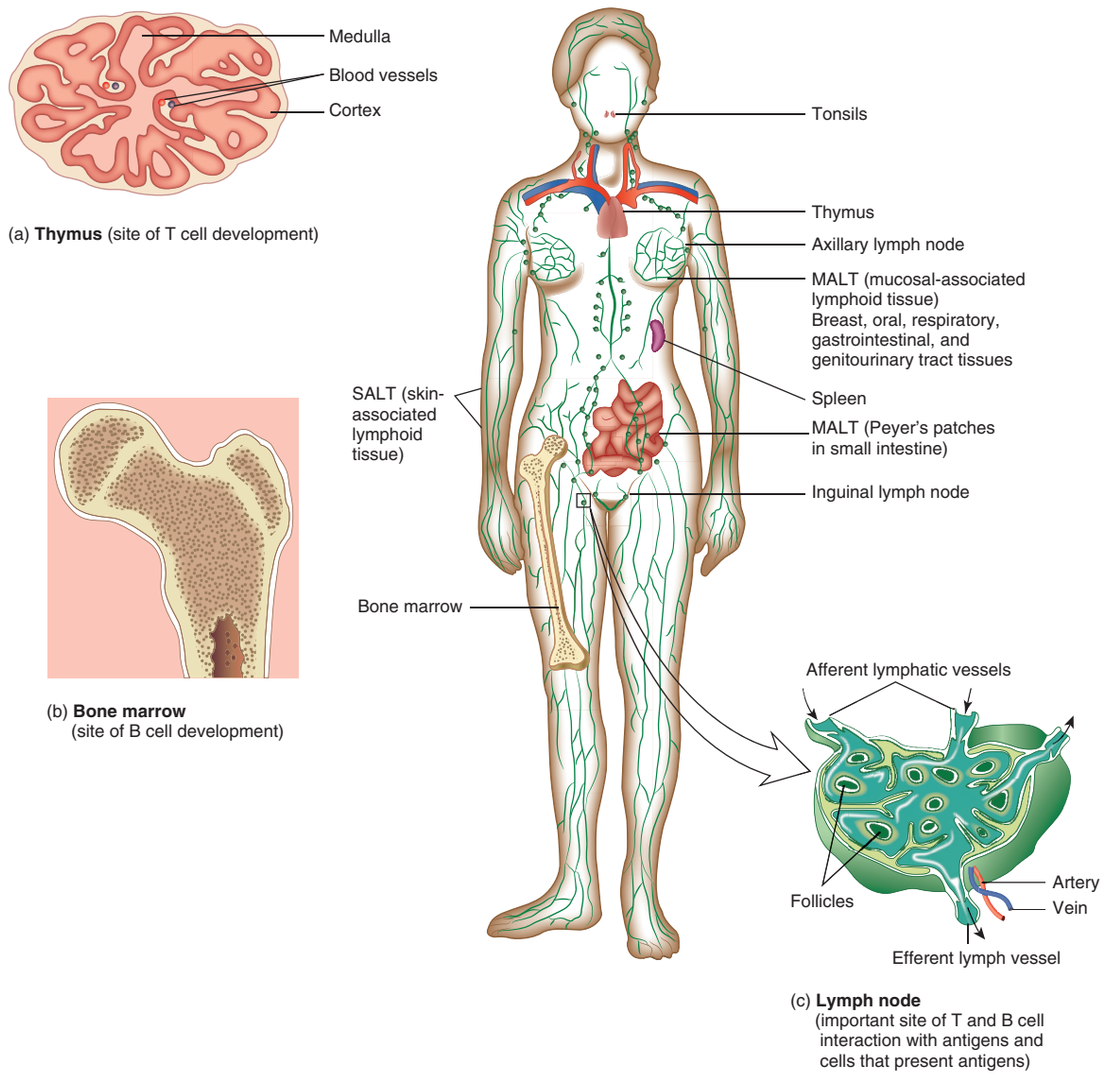


Figure 13.2: The distribution of Lymphoid tissues in the body

lobe is surrounded by a capsule and is divided into several lobules by strands of connective tissue called trabeculae. Each lobule contains an outer cortex and an inner medulla. The cortex contains many dividing immature lymphocytes. The medulla consists of reticular and epithelial cells with fewer lymphocytes and isolated Hassall's corpuscles (Figure 13.3). The primary function of the thymus is the production of mature T cells. Precursor cells from the bone marrow migrate into the outer cortex where they proliferate. As they mature, about 98% die. This is due to a process known as thymic selection in which T cells that recognize host (self) antigens are destroyed. The remaining 2% move into the medulla of the thymus, become mature T cells and subsequently enter the blood stream. These T cells recognize non host (non self) antigens.

b. Bone marrow

In mammals, the bone marrow (Figure 13.4) is the site of B cell maturation. Stromal cells within the bone marrow interact directly with the B cells and secrete various cytokines that are required for B cell development. Like

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